EAV explained | Entity + Attribute + Value

Illustrative IDs and sample values. EAV is a table design pattern, not a separate database product.

ENTITY = the record

follow_up_id	meaning
42	Follow-up for one visit

ATTRIBUTE = field definitions

attribute_id	field_key	type
501	pain_score	number
502	review_needed	boolean
503	symptom_note	text

Which record? entity_id

Which field? attribute_id

VALUE = one row per field and record

entity_id	attribute_id	value (text example)
42	501	7
42	502	true
42	503	Itching improved

Read the answer by joining:
record 42 + field pain_score + value 7
New field = new definition row, not a new SQL column.

Entity = the clinical record. Attribute = a configurable field. Value = the answer for that field on that record.

The value column above is a classic text-based example; EAV can also use typed columns. Many custom fields mean many value rows and more joins.

Your current website uses this EAV-like relationship pattern with typed JSON in value_json. EAV and JSON can be used together.